

3740. Minimum Distance Between Three Equal Elements I

Difficulty: Easy

Link: <https://leetcode.com/problems/minimum-distance-between-three-equal-elements-i/description/?envType=daily-question&envId=2026-04-10>

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Problem:

You are given an integer array `nums`.

A tuple `(i, j, k)` of 3 **distinct** indices is **good** if `nums[i] == nums[j] == nums[k]`.

The **distance** of a **good** tuple is `abs(i - j) + abs(j - k) + abs(k - i)`, where `abs(x)` denotes the **absolute value** of `x`.

Return an integer denoting the **minimum** possible **distance** of a **good** tuple. If no **good** tuples exist, return `-1`.

Example 1:

Input: `nums = [1,2,1,1,3]`

Output: 6

Explanation:

The minimum distance is achieved by the good tuple `(0, 2, 3)`.

`(0, 2, 3)` is a good tuple because `nums[0] == nums[2] == nums[3] == 1` . Its distance is `abs(0 - 2) + abs(2 - 3) + abs(3 - 0) = 2 + 1 + 3 = 6` .

Example 2:

Input: `nums = [1,1,2,3,2,1,2]`

Output: 8

Explanation:

The minimum distance is achieved by the good tuple `(2, 4, 6)` .

`(2, 4, 6)` is a good tuple because `nums[2] == nums[4] == nums[6] == 2` . Its distance is `abs(2 - 4) + abs(4 - 6) + abs(6 - 2) = 2 + 2 + 4 = 8` .

Example 3:

Input: `nums = [1]`

Output: -1

Explanation:

There are no good tuples. Therefore, the answer is -1.

Constraints:

- `1 <= n == nums.length <= 100`

- `1 <= nums[i] <= n`